

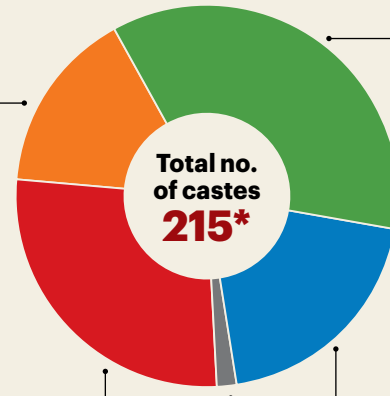
JOINING IN LJP (Ram Vilas) chief Chirag Paswan at a Bhoomi Pujan event in Hajipur, Aug. 10

THE CASTE MATRIX

The current NDA has the caste combination down pat with Nitish's EBCs, BJP's forward cohorts and Chirag's Dalit Paswan vote

Total population 130.7 MN

Hindu	81.9%
Muslim	17.7%
Others	0.4%



GENERAL 15.4% (7 CASTES)

Brahmin	3.6%
Bhumihar	2.9%
Rajput	3.4%
Kayasth	0.6%
Sheikh	3.8%
Pathan	0.7%
Saiyad	0.2%

*(Source: Bihar Caste Survey 2023; *other castes: 12))*

OBC 27.2% (30 CASTES)

Yadavs	14.3%
Kushwaha	4.2%
Kurmi	2.9%
Bania	2.3%
Surjapuri Muslims	1.9%

EBC 36% (112 CASTES)

Teli	2.8%
Mallah	2.6%
Kaanu	2.2%
Dhanuk	2.1%
Muslim castes including Momin, Julaha, Dhania, Kunjara	8.3%

SC 19.7% (22 CASTES)

Paswan	5.3%
Ravidas	5.3%
Musahar	3.1%
Paan	1.7%
Paasi	1%

ST 1.7% (32 CASTES)

Tejashwi and the RJD have the solid backing of the 32% M-Y vote, but they will need to expand the base if they are to win Bihar this time

NDA's Poll Dance

Continuity and welfare form the twin planks of the ruling alliance's campaign. The ghost of the RJD's 1990–2005 era—derisively branded 'Jungle Raj'—still stalks Bihar's political imagination, evoked in ads and memes that trade on fear and memory. The strategy is clear: to remind voters of the chaos the JD(U)-BJP combine claims to have replaced, and to stir the unease of castes wary of a return to Yadav dominance under the RJD. It is what Nitish also reiterated, saying, "Before 2005, Bihar was gripped by fear and lawlessness; people would retreat indoors at dusk. But times have changed—today there is a smile on every face."

As for the ghost of anti-incumbency, the NDA is seeking to counter it with a flurry of tangible material inducements. Besides the additional direct benefit transfer of Rs 10,000 under the Mahila Rojgar Yojana, some 18.9 million families benefit from 125 MW of free electricity, and social security pension has been raised from Rs 400 to Rs 1,100 per month. Honorariums for the 1 million Jeevika, 120,000 Anganwadi and 95,000 ASHA workers have also been increased, and a Rs 1,000 monthly allowance announced for two years for unemployed youth aged 18-25. The NDA combine will, of course, be relying on Nitish's women cohort, a bloc he has assiduously cultivated over the past two decades through welfare and quotas in addition to prohibition. The fact that female voter turnout has overshot the male turnout since 2010—it was 59.7 per cent for women in the 2020 election compared to 54.5 per cent for men—should also work as a favourable factor.

In 2020, the youth vote (18-29 age group) was split between the two alliances—37 per cent for the Mahagathbandhan (MGB) and 36 per cent for the NDA, according to an analysis